

doc-divine-simplicity

Affirms · Theology Proper › Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: medium

Statement under examination

God is not composed of parts; His attributes are identical with His essence.

Rationale

Scripture predicates being-language of God in identity-of-essence constructions: Ex 3:14 ehyeh-asher-ehyeh ('I AM THAT I AM', hayah H1961) presents God as pure self-existent being; Deut 6:4 echad H259 confesses YHWH as one; and the Johannine identity-clauses 1 John 1:5 ('God is light', phos G5457) and 1 John 4:8/16 ('God is love', agape G26) are predicate-nominative copula constructions of essential equivalence, not possession. The doctrine of simplicity (no parts, attributes identical with essence) is best read as a soft inference from this lexical pattern. Strict identity-thesis simplicity rests heavily on Aristotelian-Thomistic philosophical categories rather than direct lexical claim of any single passage, so confidence is medium-to-low and the verdict is held loosely.

Reasoning

Verdict: God is not put together from parts the way creatures are, and his attributes (love, holiness, goodness, light) are not pieces he happens to have but are identical with what he is. The strongest reason from Scripture is the way the Bible talks about God's being. In Exodus 3:14 God names himself 'I AM THAT I AM', telling Moses that his name is just being itself. Deuteronomy 6:4 says 'the LORD our God, the LORD is one', a foundational confession of his oneness. In the New Testament, 1 John 1:5 says 'God is light, and in him is no darkness at all', and 1 John 4:8 and 4:16 say 'God is love'. These verses do not say God has light or has love as one quality among many. They say God IS light and IS love. The grammar treats love and light as defining what God is, not as something he merely possesses. The strongest counterargument inside the Bible is the group of passages that seem to show God in parts or in change. Genesis 6:6 says the LORD regretted that he had made man and was grieved to his heart. Exodus 32:14 says the LORD relented from the disaster. 1 Samuel 15:11 says God repented that he had made Saul king. These passages appear to predicate emotional change of God, which a strict identity-of-attributes-with-essence reading struggles with. The verdict handles this tension partly by reading those passages as figurative speech that describes God in human terms so we can grasp his response, partly by pointing to Numbers 23:19 ('God is not a man that he should lie, nor a son of man that he should change his mind') which deliberately contrasts God with human mutability. But honest acknowledgment remains: the doctrine in its strong form (attributes are strictly identical with essence) is more a philosophical inference from how Scripture talks about God's being than a direct claim of any single verse. The Bible gives us the raw material; the doctrine of simplicity is a careful systematic conclusion drawn from that material, with help from philosophical reasoning. So the verdict stands in the soft form (God is not composed of parts like creatures are) with high confidence, but the strict identity-thesis form is held more loosely.

Denominational landscape

Divine simplicity in some form is affirmed across most historic Christian lineages, but the strength and precise content of the affirmation varies. Patristic fathers including Augustine in his treatments of the Trinity and Boethius in his theological tractates teach that God's attributes are identical with his essence; God's goodness is not something he has but something he is. The Catholic tradition follows Aquinas in Summa Theologiae Part I Question 3, where Aquinas argues across eight articles that God has no

composition of matter and form, no essence-existence distinction, no accidents, and is pure act. The Catechism of the Catholic Church teaches God's absolute oneness and immutability. Lutherans confess in the Augsburg Confession Article I that there is 'one Divine Essence, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness'. Anglicans in the 39 Articles Article I confess God 'without body, parts, or passions'. The Reformed tradition affirms simplicity strongly in the Westminster Confession 2.1 ('most pure spirit, invisible, without body, parts, or passions') and the Belgic Confession Article 1 ('a single and simple spiritual being'). Methodists in the Articles of Religion repeat the Anglican formula. Eastern Orthodoxy affirms God's simplicity in his essence but qualifies the doctrine through the essence-energies distinction of Gregory Palamas: God's essence is utterly simple and unknowable, but his energies (the divine operations by which we know him) are really distinct from his essence without dividing it. This is a nuance, not a denial. Anabaptists at Dordrecht confess the one eternal God without dispute on this point. Pentecostals in the Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths confess the one true God without explicit simplicity vocabulary but in continuity with the broader tradition. Contemporary orthodox Christian philosophers including Alvin Plantinga have raised in-house philosophical objections to the strict identity-thesis form of simplicity, arguing it makes God identical with his properties in a way that creates puzzles. This is an in-house Christian philosophical debate, not heterodoxy. Carriers of more substantive denial place themselves in tension with historic Christianity. Process theology following Alfred North Whitehead and Charles Hartshorne teaches that God has a dipolar nature in mutual relation with the world, which entails real composition. Mormonism teaches that God was once a man who progressed to godhood, which denies simplicity and the Creator-creature distinction it encodes. Some popular and academic theologies that emphasize a 'social trinity' of three distinct centers of consciousness without careful safeguards drift toward composition in God. Christians have generally affirmed the doctrine in some form for nearly two millennia, but the precise philosophical articulation continues to be discussed.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	No
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	Yes
Would serve if otherwise	Yes
Would be member if otherwise	Yes
Would let children be taught otherwise	Yes
Would marry if held otherwise	Yes
Would publicly correct if otherwise	No

Notes

Divine simplicity is a classical doctrine with deep pedigree in Augustine, Anselm, Boethius, and Aquinas (Summa Theologiae I Q3 is the locus classicus: God is His own essence; God is His own existence; God is pure act). It is affirmed by classical Reformed (Westminster Confession 2.1 'most simple'), Catholic, Lutheran (Augsburg I 'without parts'), Anglican (39 Articles I 'without body, parts, or passions'), and Eastern Orthodox traditions (though Orthodoxy nuances this with the essence-energies distinction following Gregory Palamas). However the doctrine is heavily philosophical-theological and not a direct lexical claim of any single Scripture text; it is inferred from the predications-of-being pattern. Contemporary orthodox philosophers debate the strict identity-thesis form: Alvin Plantinga's 'Does God Have a Nature?' critique of strict simplicity, and similar pushback from analytic philosophers, is in-house Christian

disagreement, not heterodoxy. Public-record carriers of denial of any meaningful divine simplicity include: process theology (Whitehead, Hartshorne, John Cobb), which holds God in mutual relation with the world and thus composed of dipolar parts; Mormonism, which teaches God was once a man working out exaltation and is thus a composite being subject to becoming; and some forms of social trinitarianism that emphasize three distinct centers of consciousness in ways that classical simplicity would resist. Fruit-vs-precision nuance: most everyday believers across all traditions implicitly affirm 'God IS love' and 'God IS holy' as identity-claims without ever framing it as 'simplicity'; the philosophical articulation matters for systematic theology but is not gospel-stake. The cult-marker bar is failed because canonical demonstration is INDIRECT (philosophical inference from predication-of-being) rather than pan-canonical lexical, and because denial of strict simplicity by orthodox philosophers like Plantinga is not gospel-denial.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: **yes**

Neutralized form. God is not composed of parts; his attributes are not separable from his essence.

Notes. The phrase 'divine simplicity' and the formulation 'attributes are identical with essence' is post-biblical philosophical-theological vocabulary inherited from Augustine, Boethius, Anselm, and Aquinas. Scripture itself never says 'God is simple' in those words. The statement asserts a strong identity-thesis form of the doctrine which is contested among orthodox Christian philosophers (Plantinga, Wolterstorff). Worked the neutralized form which softens the identity-thesis to 'attributes not separable from essence', which more accurately matches the lexical predications-of-being pattern.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. classical-philosophical-theology, accommodation, analogia-entis

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

classical-philosophical-theology · **for**: The Augustinian-Thomistic tradition reads Ex 3:14, Deut 6:4, 1 John 1:5, 1 John 4:8 plus Aristotelian categories of act-and-potency to conclude that God's essence is identical with his existence and with each of his attributes. This produces strict identity-thesis simplicity

analytic-evangelical-philosophy · **complicates**: Alvin Plantinga and similar contemporary orthodox Christian philosophers argue that strict identity-thesis simplicity collapses God's properties into one another in puzzling ways and may not be required by the biblical text. They typically affirm a softer simplicity (no composition of parts, no essence-existence distinction in the simple sense of God's being underived) while denying that every divine attribute is strictly identical with every other

essence-energies · **for-with-nuance**: Eastern Orthodox theology following Gregory Palamas affirms God's essence is utterly simple and incomprehensible, but distinguishes the energies (God's operations by which he is known and participated) from the essence. This is held as a real distinction that does not divide God. Affirms simplicity but qualifies the strict identity-thesis form

The verdict rests on (1) the predication-of-being pattern in Scripture (Ex 3:14, Deut 6:4, 1 John 1:5, 1 John 4:8, John 4:24) which uses identity-copula constructions for God's attributes, plus (2) classical philosophical-theological reasoning from Augustine, Anselm, Boethius, and Aquinas about what kind of being God must be if he is the uncaused first cause and pure act. The complicating texts (Gen 6:6, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, Jonah 3:10) are read as accommodation language, a reading the canon itself underwrites via Num 23:19 and 1 Sam 15:29. The doctrine is canonically demonstrable in the SOFT form (God is not composed of parts in the way creatures are) but its STRICT form (every attribute is strictly identical with every other) rests heavily on philosophical inference. Analogia scripturae is invoked to harmonize identity-predications with anthropopathic texts via the canon's own meta-comment on accommodation

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Exod.3.14 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key term. הָיָה אֲשֶׁר הָיָה ehyeh asher ehyeh; hayah H1961

Force. hayah = to be, exist, become. First person common singular imperfect, 'I AM that I AM' or 'I will be what I will be'. Divine self-naming as pure being / self-existence. The classical Christian tradition reads this as God identifying himself with being itself (ipsum esse subsistens in Aquinas), the canonical seed of the simplicity doctrine. The repetition and the absolute first-person predication ground the inference that in God essence and existence are not distinct

Deut.6.4 · **for** · genre: law

Key term. יְהוָה אֱחָד echad H259, YHWH H3068

Force. echad = one, single, unified. The Shema's confession that YHWH is one. Primarily about numerical singularity and exclusive devotion in its original setting, but read by classical theology (Augustine, Aquinas) as foundational for simplicity: the one God is one in being, not many parts assembled. Adjective masculine singular as predicate

1John.1.5 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ θεὸς φῶς ἐστίν; theos G2316, phos G5457, estin G1510

Force. Predicate-nominative copula construction: 'God is light'. Both theos and phos in nominative; estin (present indicative of eimi) functions as identity-of-being copula. The grammar treats light as defining what God is, not as something he possesses among other parts. Standard Johannine identity-clause; one of the canonical anchors for simplicity

1John.4.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ θεὸς ἀγάπη ἐστίν; theos G2316, agape G26, estin G1510

Force. 'God is love'. Predicate-nominative copula: theos nominative, agape nominative, estin third person singular present indicative. Identity-of-being predication, not possession. Combined with 1 John 4:16 ('God is love' repeated) this is the strongest New Testament anchor for the simplicity claim that God's attributes are identical with his essence. He does not have love as one part; he IS love

John.4.24 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key term. πνεῦμα ὁ θεός; pneuma G4151, theos G2316

Force. 'God is spirit'. Predicate-nominative without article on pneuma, copula understood. Anchors God's incorporeality (no body, no material parts). Foundational for the 'without body, without parts' confession of the historic creeds. Genre is gospel dialogue with the Samaritan woman

Heb.6.13 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὅμοσεν καθ' ἑαυτοῦ; omnumi G3660, heautou G1438

Force. 'Because he had no one greater by whom to swear, he swore by himself'. God swears by his own being because nothing is greater. Anchors aseity (self-existence) which is logically tied to simplicity in the classical synthesis: if God depends on nothing outside himself and nothing exists greater than him, then his being is not received from any parts assembled

Mal.3.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. יְהוָה אֵל הוּא יָבֹא shanah H8138

Force. shanah = to change, alter. 'I the LORD do not change'. Immutability is closely linked to simplicity in the classical synthesis: a being composed of parts could lose or gain a part and thus change; an utterly simple being cannot. Direct lexical anchor for immutability, indirect anchor for simplicity

Jas.1.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. παρ' ᾧ οὐκ ἔνι παραλλαγὴ ἢ τροπὴ ἀποσκίασμα; parallage G3883, tropes G5157

Force. parallage = variation, change; trope = turning, shifting. 'With whom there is no variation or shadow due to change'. Reinforces immutability and indirectly simplicity. The Father of lights does not vary because there are no parts in him to rearrange or shift

Num.23.19 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. מִתְנַחֵם קִדְּא־נָבוּ בְּזַכִּי לֹא שִׂיא אֵל; nacham H5162

Force. nacham (Hithpael) = to change one's mind, relent, repent. Here negated: 'God is not a man that he should lie, nor a son of man that he should change his mind'. Functions as the canonical hermeneutical key for anthropopathic regret texts: they are accommodation language, not literal divine change. Supports simplicity by showing Scripture itself signals when change-language is figurative

Gen.6.6 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism, anthropomorphism

Key term. וְגַם לֹא בָצַעְתִּי קִדְּאָה תָּא הָשַׁע יֵכ הוּאִי מִתְנִי; nacham H5162, atsab H6087

Force. nacham = to be sorry, regret; atsab = to grieve, be pained. 'The LORD regretted that he had made man, and it grieved him to his heart'. Anthropopathic predication of regret and grief onto God. Complicates strict identity-thesis simplicity because if attributes are identical with essence and essence is immutable, predicating change-of-affect onto God must be read as accommodation language. The classical tradition (Augustine, Aquinas) reads exactly this way. The text itself, taken at face value, complicates strict simplicity

Exod.32.14 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. הִעָרָה לַע הוּאִי מִתְנִי; nacham H5162

Force. 'And the LORD relented from the disaster that he had spoken of bringing on his people'. Same Niphal of nacham as Gen 6:6. After Moses' intercession, the LORD changes his stated course. Strict simplicity must read this as accommodation describing God's response from the human standpoint, not literal change in God. Honestly complicates the doctrine at the lexical level

1Sam.15.11 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. לֹא־שָׂא תָא יִתְכַלְמָה יֵכ יִתְמַחַנ; nacham H5162

Force. First-person divine speech: 'I regret that I have made Saul king'. nacham in Niphal first person common singular perfect. Compounded by 1 Sam 15:29 in the same chapter saying 'the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret (nacham), for he is not a man that he should have regret'. The same chapter both predicates and denies nacham of God, signaling that the predication is figurative

Jonah.3.10 · complicates · genre: prophecy · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. הִעָרָה לַע מִיְהִלָּאָה מִתְנִי; nacham H5162

Force. 'God relented of the disaster that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it'. Same anthropopathic nacham. Strict simplicity must harmonize via accommodation reading: God's unchanging will eternally included the conditional response to Nineveh's repentance, so what looks like change is unchanging conditional decree from the divine side

Concordance lemmas traversed

H1961, H259, H3068, H5162, H6087, H8138, G2316, G5457, G26, G1510, G4151, G3660, G3883, G5157

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, De Trinitate, especially books V-VII on the divine attributes · affirms · unverified

“Augustine teaches that in God to be is the same as to be good, to be wise, to be great. God's attributes are not accidents added to his essence; they are identical with his essence”

catholic_magisterial · Aquinas, Summa Theologiae I Q3 (eight articles on divine simplicity) · affirms · verified

“God is the same as His essence or nature. God is not only His own essence but also His own existence. Pure act without potentiality (locus classicus for the doctrine)”

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article I, Of God · affirms · verified

“one Divine Essence which is called and which is God: eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness”

anglican · 39 Articles, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity · affirms · unverified

“There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions; of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness. Direct confession of simplicity in the 'without parts' clause”

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 2.1; Belgic Confession Article 1 · affirms · unverified

“WCF 2.1: God is 'a most pure spirit, invisible, without body, parts, or passions, immutable, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty, most wise, most holy, most free, most absolute'. Belgic 1: 'a single and simple spiritual being”

methodist · Methodist Articles of Religion, Article I · affirms · verified

“There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness. Direct confession of simplicity inherited from the Anglican formula via Wesley”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith Article 1, Of God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“We believe in one eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God. The Anabaptist confession does not articulate simplicity philosophically but confesses the one indivisible God of Scripture”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 2, The One True God · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent 'I AM'. The AG statement uses the Ex 3:14 self-existence language but does not articulate philosophical simplicity explicitly”

eastern_orthodox · OCA, The Orthodox Faith, on God's nature; Gregory Palamas on the essence-energies distinction · affirms · verified

“God is so unique and so perfect that His existence cannot be compared to any other. Orthodoxy affirms God's essence is simple and unknowable while distinguishing his energies, qualifying strict identity-thesis simplicity”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/exodus/3-14.htm>

“ehyeh asher ehyeh; hayah H1961 first person common singular imperfect; 'to be, exist, become'; divine self-naming as pure being”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/deuteronomy/6-4.htm>

“echad H259 'one'; predicate masculine singular adjective on YHWH; the Shema's confession of divine oneness, foundational for simplicity”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_john/4-8.htm

“ho theos agape estin: predicate-nominative copula construction; identity-of-being predication, not possession; theos G2316, agape G26, estin G1510”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_john/1-5.htm

“ho theos phos estin: identity-of-being construction; God's nature IS luminousness, not a temporary quality; theos G2316, phos G5457”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/numbers/23-19.htm>

“nacham H5162 negated of God; 'God is not a man that he should lie, nor a son of man that he should change his mind'; canonical hermeneutical key for anthropopathic regret texts”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/6-6.htm>

“nacham H5162 + atsab H6087 predicated of YHWH; 'the LORD regretted... and it grieved him to his heart'; anthropopathic complication for strict simplicity”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/1003.htm>

“Aquinas ST I Q3: 'God is the same as His essence or nature... God is not only His own essence but also His own existence... pure act without potentiality'. Locus classicus for divine simplicity”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“Augsburg Confession Article I: 'one Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.churchofengland.org/prayer-and-worship/worship-texts-and-resources/book-common-prayer/articles-religion>

“39 Articles Article I: 'There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions; of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness'. Direct confession of simplicity”

nuance · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/god>

“OCA: 'God is so unique and so perfect that His existence cannot be compared to any other. In this sense God is above existence or above being'. Orthodox affirmation with essence-energies nuance”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Articles of Religion Article I: 'There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness”

Flags

- stem-pre-loaded-verdict
- confession-tradition-divergence
- philosophical-theology-not-direct-lexical